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Patrick P. Molutsi

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The State, Environment and Peasant Consciousness in Botswana

Patrick P. Molutsi

Introduction

Environmental management — one of the pressing problems of the 1980s — is intricately intertwined with wider issues of poverty, land concentration, inequality, and gender. In recent years bourgeois and Marxist scholars have rightly shown increasing interest in the subject of environmental management and related issues. For those of us in the underdeveloped part of the world, the problem of the environment is not so much the threat of pollution and nuclear contamination, as the pressing problems of poverty and famine. For us, it is urgent that scholars, practitioners and producers combine efforts to find solutions to overgrazing, soil erosion, desertification, and famine, all the more so because these environmental problems are not of recent origin.

British colonial reports from Africa and India show that drought was one of the key issues discussed between 1900 and 1960. The most striking feature of these reports is that, in every case, drought was largely blamed on such methods of production as shifting cultivation, overstocking, and bush fires, which were very often cited as major man-made causes of drought and desertification. In contrast, capitalist agricultural practices, even when they exposed soil to heat and sun and thus made it more susceptible to erosion, were not usually thought to threaten the environment.

The colonial government simply reduced complex environmental problems to two opposing ideologies — on the one hand, colonial capitalism, which with its superior production techniques was environmentally more efficient, and on the other, peasant production, culture and way of life, which were dismissed as inefficient, poor and environmentally disastrous. This approach to environmental problems is still characteristic of post-colonial policies.

This article traces the history of conservation policies in Botswana. It argues that in Botswana, as in many post-colonial states, especially those following a capitalist path of development, conservation and sound environmental management are reduced to ideology. Overgrazing and soil erosion are still called the consequences of peasant production methods, and the solutions proposed are still individual land tenure, fencing, and commercial capitalist agriculture. This approach has enabled a few petty bourgeois to accumulate large tracts of tribal land measuring 8 km² each as private ranches. The process of land accumulation is more

pronounced in the western parts of the country where peasant resistance is strongest. Government environmental policies fail to reduce overgrazing because they are simplistic and really intended to facilitate the process of capitalist accumulation in the countryside. In a number of instances, freehold farms and ranches leased to individuals are more overgrazed than peasant lands.

Peasants are not as naive as the literature portrays them. Though often reduced to bystanders in the drama of development, they can become revolutionaries, as every regime knows, when there is interference with their land and cattle. Even brute force does not usually succeed in displacing them from their original habitats. Botswana's peasants have adopted different strategies to resist both changes in land tenure and environmental policies that appeared to reduce their stock. For example, in 1985 some peasants, mostly Hereros from Namibia who had been living in Botswana since 1906, chose to return to Namibia rather than accept the newly introduced Tribal Grazing Land Policy (TGLP). In the Ngwaketse region and Kweneng District where ranch accumulation by petty bourgeois farmers has been most aggressive, peasant protests compelled the government to dezone some land designated for commercial ranching. Thus, the state has returned some land to the community, not because it is democratic and benevolent, but because this crude capital accumulation process engendered peasant resistance and a revolutionary atmosphere in the countryside.

Resistance has not been sufficient to block the petty bourgeoisie. Thousands of peasants were displaced from their natural habitats as cattle and boreholes moved in. This displacement pauperised some peasants, forcing them to rely on government food handouts. Many work herding cattle belonging to absentee landlords for pitiful wages, which are often paid in kind with tobacco and mealie meal.

This article concludes with sad evidence that Botswana has not yet seriously addressed its environmental problems. Instead, its capitalist policies, dressed in the language of conservation, have sharpened rural class distinctions, worsened grazing conditions, and increased soil erosion, the frequency of drought, famine, and mass poverty.

The Pre-colonial Environment

Botswana has always been a dry country with a harsh climate. Over 60% of the land lies in the Kalahari semi-desert on the west. Only 5% of the total land area is suitable for both livestock and agricultural production. The population is concentrated on the eastern side of the country and only thinly distributed in the west. The average rainfall is 450mm; it is highest in the northwest and lowest in the Kalahari. The only area with good rains is the Okavango, but it is infested by tsetse fly and has only patches of fertile soils.

Archaeological evidence is not yet conclusive but it is probable that modern Botswana was not settled until the 18th century. In the 19th century, European missionaries, travellers, hunters and colonial officers recorded the Tswana mode of production. According to these sources, the Tswana were a settled people with an economy based on cattle and crop production as well as arts and crafts, tanning and black smithing industries. These predominantly subsistent peasant communities were by no means prosperous. Output was low, technology rudimentary, and production fluctuated with droughts and cattle disease.

The communal land system enabled people to move their cattle freely or to acquire new fields. They did not have to buy land but merely to obtain permission to use it from their chief or his representative. The peasants adopted shifting cultivation to allow exhausted soils to recover fertility and to maximise crop returns. Because rainfall was erratic, most peasants scattered their fields in different parts of the village. They say that they were 'chasing showers'. In order to provide water for people and livestock, the Tswana used to dig pits, wells and dams, which they abandoned when the water dried up. Throughout the country, people burned parts of their grazing land to prepare for the new season.

The people lived in separated settlements of villages, lands, and cattle posts. The last two were generally smaller than the villages, which were the centre of activity and where the chief resided. The reasons for the tripartite settlement pattern have yet to be fully investigated. One hypothesis is that, in the absence of fences, only distance could separate cattle from crops. This is plausible but does not explain why the pattern is unique in southern Africa to the Tswana. Another hypothesis is that, because the 19th century was a period of frequent warfare, the Tswana adopted this strategy to keep their resources away from potential enemies. During the war these separated settlements distanced invaders and created a hiding place especially for women, children and livestock. Whichever hypothesis is the correct one, it seems that the movement of people with sledges and carts between the settlements may have contributed to the country's present soil erosion problems. Although there are reports that designated overseers in each area determined when a piece of land was overgrazed, there is not enough evidence to suggest how far this conservation method was successful.

There was also a traditional system of the larger herders loaning out cattle to those with few, who got their milk and the first off-spring in return for herding them; it was called *mafisa*. Although embodying relations of inequality and exploitation of the poor by the rich, the *mafisa* system provided some form of social security for the poor.

This summary of Tswana methods of production, which has implications for environmental conservation, is necessary to an understanding of colonial and post-colonial environmental ideologies. The next section reviews the colonial response to Tswana political economy.

The British Colonial Political Economy and Environmental Management

The ideology of conservation has its history in colonial rule in Bechuanaland. The colonial government divided the country into Native Reserves covering 48% of the total area, but later regretted having made that decision. It then tried different policies to dissolve the communal tenure of the reserves and to install a freehold tenure system.

From the late 1930s the colonial government provided limited funds for livestock development. Most of this money was used to drill syndicate boreholes. This policy did not change tenure, however, and in the late 1940s the state adopted a different strategy.

After World War II, the government provided loans and technical assistance to individual large cattle owners to drill their own boreholes in the western parts of the country. Money for borehole development took a large share of revenue during this period. Of the total of 2,782,418 loans and grants voted to the Bechuanaland

Administration between 1945 and 1956, 60% was spent on agriculture and, under agriculture, almost half (49%) was spent on water development. The strategy of helping large cattle owners move into the Kalahari was quite successful after WWII. The government succeeded in creating *de facto* private holdings of land there, which did change land tenure patterns. Although there was talk of conservation, the primary concern was with commercial exchange.

The British believed Bechuanaland to be an open land with potential for commercial ranching, as various commissions sent to the Protectorate unflinching stressed. The Gaitskell Mission of 1954, for instance, stated:

we believe that this immense land, happy in being without history, largely empty of people . . . and therefore free for the future can with patience, wisdom and imaginative use, be moulded into a steady and enduring model in miniature of African, coloured, and European partnership in the fullest sense of the word.

This mission, as did earlier ones, falsely claimed that Bechuanaland was an empty land, even though the Kalanga and other communities had been living in this part of the country for many years.

The effect of the consequent huge investment in livestock production and marketing was a quantum increase in the number of cattle. The national herd has grown apace, despite severe set-backs in drought years — one million in the 1930s, two million in the 1960s, and now approaching three million. The increase in the commercial off-take, almost all for export, is an indicator. In 1942, 45,000 head of cattle were exported; in 1946 the number increased to 47,000 and in 1950 to around 70,000. In 1959 the number rose to 90,000 and in 1962 to 118,000. The invasion of the Kalahari was thus well started by the end of colonial rule.

Post-Colonial Environmental Policies

The environmental policies of the post-colonial government revolve around three simplistic beliefs: a) that poor conservation methods are caused by the communal land tenure system and that individual land tenure is superior to communal tenure because the owner is obliged to protect his/her land; b) that communal tenure and chiefly rule restrict movement and deny people permanent settlement in their place of choice (i.e., that the chief's methods of land allocation and general restrictions on people's movement created insecurity among producers, reduced agricultural investment, and kept levels of output low; chiefs are therefore accused of promoting retrogressive attitudes, poverty and disease); and c) that a technical and bureaucratic package can promote better conservation and increase agricultural output.

The government's solutions to conservation and low productivity are: 1) appropriate legislation to provide change of tenure of grazing land from communal to some form of individual tenure — freehold or leasehold (the 1968 act, which transferred the administration of tribal lands from the chiefs to the newly established land boards, provided terms for leasehold tenure in agriculture for the first time); 2) modern methods of livestock production — fencing, rotation grazing, stock breeding and control, which when applied give both better conservation methods and increased production; and 3) the use of Botswana's vast empty land to which individual ranches can be allocated. In reply to opponents of the Tribal Land Act, the then Vice President Dr. Masire said,

not only will the Act put people's rights to their land on a proper democratic basis, but progressive farmers will be greatly assisted in their efforts to increase productivity.

44 *REVIEW OF AFRICAN POLITICAL ECONOMY*

Furthermore, ...the farmers brigades (cooperatives of young farmers) will be unhindered by outmoded restrictions.

The Tribal Grazing Land Policy (TGLP) of 1975, the government's second major piece of legislation designed to change the tribal/communal tenure system, officially legitimised the invasion of the Kalahari. This policy divided tribal land into commercial, communal, and reserve areas. The commercial areas were lands set aside for commercial ranch development based on a leasehold land tenure system. The lessors were predominantly to be large cattle owners. Communal areas, on the other hand, were to be for poor and middle peasants who were to retain the communal tenure system and graze their stock around the already overgrazed villages. Only if they were formed into cooperatives would poor and middle peasants be permitted to move to commercial areas. The reserve areas which were to be for future generations and wildlife never came into existence. Land use surveys showed that the anticipated empty land was unavailable.

When launching the act in 1975, the late President Khama said,

increased herds, under the system of uncontrolled grazing, have led to serious overgrazing around villages, surface water sources and boreholes. Overgrazing has led to sheet erosion and bush encroachment which reduced the amount of good grazing.

The solutions according to the President are:

...using simple methods of management (rotational grazing, controlled breeding, early weaning, daily watering and bonemeal feeding). Correct stocking rates, and paddocking to permit some rotational grazing will halt deterioration, allow the grass to improve, and provide standing hay for the dry season.

The TGLP succeeded in giving both former state land and tribal land to individual ranchers. Although they were already large, the sizes of the ranches in the west were increased, whereas long overcrowded districts such as the northeast, southeast, and Kweneng received only small additions of new land. It is not difficult to establish who benefited from this tenorial change. As President Khama once said:

Botswana is and will remain a nation of farmers. I and most of my cabinet are farmers. Most of our civil servants retain close personal and family links with the land. So our rural development policies are based on practical experience as well as modern methods of extension and applied research.

Government conservation policies have in practice served the major purpose of privatising grazing land rather than of promoting better environmental management. By 1979 the whole country was divided into different types of land tenure. Although some commercial land was reduced and given over to communal, the overall effect of the policy has been to privatise communal land.

Reaction and Resistance to Government Land Policies

TGLP was reluctantly accepted by peasants in 1975. Many saw it not as a conservation policy but as a programme of destocking and privatising tribal land. In some western parts of the country peasant objections to the policy were very strong because most of the private ranches had expanded into these areas earlier. In the years since TGLP was introduced, peasant resistance to this policy has increased. First of all, government failed to make good its promise to reserve areas for the poorer members of society and future generations of cattle owners. Second, from 1975 to 1986 government concentrated resources on the development of commercial ranches and totally neglected communal areas. Third, commercial

ranches displaced large numbers of people, paying little or no compensation. Despite their acquisition of large ranches (some over 1,000 hectares), large stock owners have neither removed all of their cattle from overgrazed villages nor practised better conservation methods in the newly acquired ranches.

University students and researchers opposed TGLP from the start, comparing it to the English enclosure system of the 18th century. Picard and Holms are wrong to claim that only some expatriate personnel and young civil servants criticised the policy. They were but a small section of a larger group who were personally opposed to this policy. Some private and governmental institutions such as the National Institute for Research of the University of Botswana and the Rural Sociology Unit of the Ministry of Agriculture also made similar assessments of this policy just before its implementation. These reports raised issues ranging from the technical and economic to the social and political implications of this policy. Over all, participants in the workshops, which produced the NIR and Sociology Unit reports, were skeptical of TGLP. Since these reports, Sandford, Hitchcock, Lipton, Holms, and the annual reports of the Second Livestock Development Project have shown that TGLP has faced many problems, some of which such as the effects on the poor and non-cattle owners were predicted by early critics of the policy.

Rural protest, against TGLP in particular and state conservation policies in general, has increased over the years. In Kweneng District, for instance, the protest was so strong that government concluded either that the Bakwena were unnecessarily hostile to this policy or that they were politically motivated by the opposition parties to reject it. However, the reasons why Bakwena more than other Batswana have been most vocal against this policy are not hard to find. Kweneng is the largest of the districts close to Gaborone; the other neighbouring districts of Kgatieng and southeast are small and do not have any land demarcated for commercial ranches. As a result, initiatives to commercialise Bakwena land at the expense of the peasants came from both Gaborone, where petty bourgeois cattle owners are concentrated, and from the neighbouring districts.

In the Ngwaketse region, too, where the land grab process created by the TGLP was very tense, protest was strong. Various individuals of high political and social standing allocated large ranches to themselves. In the end 60% of the land was declared commercial, leaving many peasants with no land. To address this situation a commission was set up in 1980 to investigate land allocation irregularities. The findings of this commission showed the crude and adverse ways in which TGLP has been used by the ruling class in Botswana to accumulate land.

The State and its Development Ideology

Many post-colonial states claim that, because they are neither capitalist nor socialist, they have no ideology. Still others claim that their ideologies are based on their past traditions and customs. Botswana defines ideology in terms of either capitalism or socialism and claims that because it identifies with neither of the two it therefore has no ideology. While denying its capitalist character, Botswana dismissed socialism outright as irrelevant to the country. In the words of the late President Khama:

Many African countries have formally stated that their guiding ideology is socialism. This label, even if qualified by the adjective 'African', can have little meaning for the majority of our people. Furthermore, socialism is an ideology to which leaders as various as Stalin and Dubcek, Ulbricht and Willy Brandt, Nasser and Ben Gurion, Harold Wilson and Fidel Castro

have all laid claim.

More recently President Masire claimed that his government is social democratic. He said this was because its policies encourage both free enterprise and parastatal (partly private and partly state owned) organizations to invest freely in the economy.

At another level, the government claims it has no ideology but has guiding principles of development, democracy, national unity, and self-reliance. These are said to be principles rooted in the culture of Botswana, perhaps only because they can be translated into the local language. The four national principles are then simplified into four planning objectives, of rapid economic growth, sustained development, economic independence, and social justice.

Of these four, only the first, rapid economic growth, has been realised in the 20 years since independence. There are no signs of reduced economic dependence on external capital and multinational corporations. Instead, Botswana's dependence on South Africa, foreign companies and governments has grown substantially in the past two decades. The record for sustained development and social justice is a very poor one. The land on which both sustained development and rapid economic growth depend is under serious threat of desertification. Social justice is a controversial bourgeois concept claimed by all governments. Yet in Botswana, poverty is widespread, unemployment is growing, and gross inequality in incomes is aggravated by displacement of the population these are hardly good signs of social justice regardless of how one defines it. Indeed, in its recent development plans, the government conceded that the four planning principles are inconsistent.

Of course it is not what leaders say or do not say that defines a country's ideology. The dominant relations of production define the ideology of the state at any particular point in time. Close observation of Botswana's social formation 20 years after independence shows three basic features. First, land tenure has changed significantly from a communal non-marketable system to a privatised freehold/leasehold marketable system. In other words, the community has lost control and ownership of the land to individuals. Second, many households are increasingly dependent on wage labour and on remittances and gifts from relatives employed in the wage sector. In contrast, the agricultural sector which in the past provided many people with a living has been declining in both relative and absolute terms. Third, both property ownership and relations of production have become increasingly privatised and profit oriented. Not only has foreign capital dominated the economy and determined the levels of return to labour, but also the indigenous livestock industry has become more commercialised. Recent surveys in the rural areas show that increasing numbers of cattle owners no longer use their cattle for draught power, preferring either to buy a tractor or to give up farming altogether.

These changes in the method of production have had substantial impact on the relations of production; in particular the decline of the traditional mafisa practice of loaning cattle has been partly responsible for widespread poverty in rural Botswana. The above three major characteristics of Botswana's political economy show a capitalist society in the making. It is therefore ridiculous for the state to continue to claim that it has no ideology.

Conclusion

Botswana faces three major problems in the next two decades. In order of importance these problems are poverty, unemployment, and environmental degradation. Although ranking third, environmental issues are intricately related to the problems of poverty, inequality, and unemployment. Under existing environmental conditions, the problems of poverty and agricultural underproduction cannot be tackled adequately. And without first addressing the problem of environmental conservation, it will be extremely difficult to create more jobs in the agricultural sector.

Future environmental policies will not gain peasant support easily, judging by the struggle against TGLP in both Kweneng District and the Ngwaketse region. The recently introduced National Conservation Policy faces a gloomy future. It is sad, therefore, to conclude that the post-colonial state, as did its predecessor uses environmental issues as an ideology to justify capitalist accumulation of land.

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